

FISH SNATCHER
Forest-fringed swamps are perfect habitats for Pel's fishing owl, a huge bird capable of grabbing fish weighing 2-5 lb (1-2 kg) in its talons.

PEL'S FISHING OWL

FRIEND OR FOE?

Often seen on the backs of hoofed grazers, oxpeckers are small perching birds that specialize in feeding on ticks and other skin parasites that afflict mammals. Their services may not be entirely benign: they also peck at wounds as a source of blood.

RED-BILLED OXPECKER

Highly endangered black and white rhinoceros have adapted to wetland life here

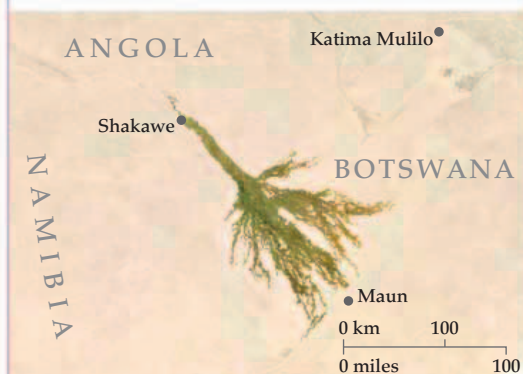
BORN SURVIVOR

A lungfish thrives in oxygen-poor waters due to a lunglike offshoot of the gut that extracts oxygen as the fish gulps air. During droughts, the fish squirms into mud and forms a slime cocoon to hold air and moisture that keep it alive until water returns.

WEST AFRICAN LUNGFISH

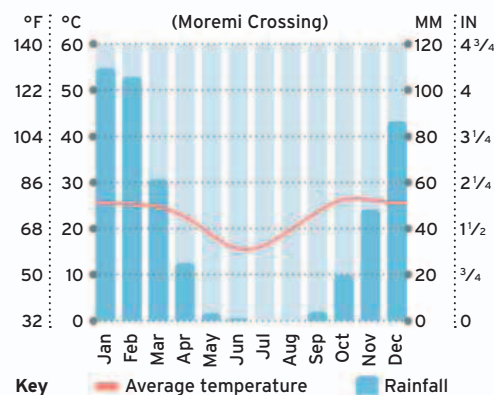
LOCATION

The Okavango River rises in the highlands of Angola, and flows southeast into Botswana, where it spreads out to form the vast delta landscape.



CLIMATE

Most of the rain reaching the delta falls in the Angolan part of the Okavango river catchment area during the hot, humid summer months (December-February). Winters are dry and mainly mild, though nighttime temperatures may approach freezing.



NO WAY OUT

The Okavango Delta is an endorheic basin: a closed water system that does not involve the sea. Rain falling over such an area drains via rivers into a low point, forming a lake, inland sea (such as the Caspian), or a swamp. There is no route by which water can flow to the ocean, and all water flowing in is lost through evaporation or gradual seepage into the ground.

